Reading The Rose of Versailles Through Digital Editing: Comparing Transcription and Encoding Methods

(The following project is based on the report: "Reading Gender Through Digital Methods: A Digital History Project on Female Representation in 1970s Shōjo Manga".)

Introduction

Digital Humanities (DH) tools help researchers organise, edit, and analyse large text collections. Rather than simply creating digital copies of sources, these tools can build searchable corpora, record contextual information, and support new forms of analysis, thereby increasing opportunities for collaboration and accessibility among scholars (Cohen and Rosenzweig, 2006). However, digital humanities work remains largely text-focused, and some projects rely on simplistic interfaces that fail to utilise databases to their full potential, limiting their effectiveness (Nygren and Buckland, 2014, p. 15).

This post explores how Riyoko Ikeda's *The Rose of Versailles* could be prepared as a digital corpus for studying representations of women and gender. First serialised between 1972 and 1973, the manga follows Marie Antoinette and Oscar François de Jarjayes, a woman raised as a man who serves in the Royal Guards (Anan, 2014). To create a usable corpus, this project examines several tools and methods, including Transkribus, eScriptorium, TEI, and general-purpose multimodal AI systems.

The Editorial Situation

A corpus, defined as a "collection of machine-readable authentic texts" (Xiao, 2010, p. 147), would be used in *The Rose of Versailles* to investigate the representation of female characters and gender identities, a theme often examined in scholarly discussion of shoujo manga (cf. Shahwan, Pillai and Mat Saad, 2026). The corpus would consist primarily of dialogue and narration extracted from the manga, with particular attention to major female characters such as Oscar François de Jarjayes and Marie Antoinette, whose relationship remains central to the story.

A key challenge is that manga combine text and visuals and often use film-like techniques (Shannon, 2011, p. 21). Thus, editors must decide which aspects of the source to preserve through transcription and encoding; automated tools can reduce manual work but cannot replace the importance of editorial work. Therefore, several editorial approaches are possible. A documentary edition aims to preserve the source's visual and textual features as closely as possible. In contrast, digital scholarly editions may also be designed around specific research questions and analytical goals (cf. Pierazzo, 2015). Because this project investigates gender representation rather than textual reconstruction, a research-oriented digital edition is the most appropriate approach.

Transcription Methods

One possible approach is to use Transkribus, an "AI-powered platform designed to simplify transcription and digitisation of documents, from historical manuscripts to modern records", using a wide range of recognition models (Transkribus, n.d.). It offers pre-trained and custom models, supports collaboration, and allows export in formats suitable for further editing and encoding. Another option is eScriptorium, an open-source platform for transcribing and recognising historical documents. It integrates image segmentation, transcription, and handwritten text recognition within a single workflow (eScriptorium, n.d.).

General-purpose multimodal AI systems such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, and Claude can also assist with transcription tasks. These systems can identify text within images, suggest speakers, generate metadata, and organise information (OpenAI, 2023; Microsoft, n.d.; Google AI, n.d.; Anthropic, n.d.). Unlike specialised HTR platforms such as Transkribus or eScriptorium, however, they were not designed specifically for scholarly transcription workflows. Although efficient, they may introduce transcription errors or misinterpret visual context, making human review essential.

T-PEN represents another historically significant transcription environment. It allows users to work directly with images while manually entering text and exporting data in formats such as XML (Cole, 2012). It also supports collaborative transcription and multiple viewing modes (T-PEN, n.d.). However, T-PEN is no longer actively developed. While it remains useful for understanding manual transcription workflows, contemporary projects may benefit more from platforms such as Transkribus and eScriptorium, which continue to receive support and development.

If high-quality page images were available through the International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF), they could be shared, referenced, and connected directly to transcriptions. IIIF would make it easier to link specific regions of manga pages to encoded text and annotations, improving both accessibility and interoperability (IIIF Consortium, n.d.).

Encoding and Editing Methods

Once the text is transcribed, it needs to be organised to support research and analysis, using a format such as plain text, which requires little technical know-how. However, plain text does not preserve contextual information in a structured form (Burnard, 2014).

A more sophisticated method would involve the Text Encoding Initiative (TEI). According to Burnard (2014), TEI provides guidelines for representing humanities texts in digital form and enables researchers to encode both textual structure and meaning. Using TEI, researchers can identify character names with <persName> tags, locations with <placeName> tags, and relationships through appropriate encoding structures. In this manner, references to Oscar François de Jarjayes and Marie Antoinette could be tagged consistently throughout the corpus.

The principal advantage of TEI is that it preserves information that would otherwise be difficult to capture in plain text. TEI is also widely recognised within the digital humanities and promotes long-term accessibility and interoperability. However, it has limitations. As Cummings (2019) notes, TEI projects can become highly complex and require significant time and technical expertise, including interpretive decisions about what to encode and how to represent it.

TEI could be implemented using Oxygen XML Editor (Oxygen XML Editor, n.d.). The resulting XML files could also be enriched through annotation tools discussed in the course. Platforms such as Recogito, Digital Mappa, EUPORIA, or PUNDIT could be used to annotate characters, places, themes, or relationships and connect the corpus to wider research datasets (Recogito, n.d.; Digital Mappa, n.d.; EUPORIA, n.d.; PUNDIT, n.d.).

Analysis and Preferred Workflow

Following transcription and encoding, the corpus could be analysed using Voyant Tools. Voyant enables researchers to examine word frequencies, collocations, and thematic patterns across a corpus. Such analysis could reveal recurring associations between particular characters and concepts such as femininity, authority, duty, or love. However, Voyant cannot interpret meaning independently and should therefore complement rather than replace close reading (McGraw Center for Teaching and Learning, n.d.).

Although frequency-based analysis can be useful, the project's greatest analytical value would likely come from structured encoding and annotation (Burnard, 2014). TEI tags and annotations would make it possible to trace characters, relationships, and representations of gender throughout the corpus in ways that simple word counts cannot (Burnard, 2014).

In conclusion, for this editorial situation, the most effective workflow would combine AI-assisted transcription in Transkribus or eScriptorium with human correction, followed by TEI encoding in Oxygen XML Editor (Oxygen XML Editor, n.d.) and additional annotation using tools such as Recogito (Recogito, n.d.) or Digital Mappa (Digital Mappa, n.d.). Voyant could then be used as a supplementary analytical tool. This workflow balances efficiency and accuracy, preserves contextual information, and supports future research. Compared with either a fully manual workflow or a completely automated one, it provides a stronger foundation for scholarly investigation.

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